



▲ **Divine touch**

This mid-17th-century fresco shows French king Francis I, an advocate of the divine right of kings, offering his healing touch to those with scrofula during his visit to Bologna in 1515.

THE HIGH ARTS OF RITUAL

ceremonial magic

The performance of ceremonial (ritual) magic gained momentum during the Renaissance. In contrast with natural magic (see p.144), which celebrated the innate wonders of nature, ritual magic involved the use of specific actions, ceremonies, and tools in a set order, often with the aim of summoning spirits. So a natural magic practitioner might focus on the stars themselves, and a ceremonial magician on invoking astrological spirits as a part of their occult practice.

Official sanction

Although the Catholic Church was intolerant of any non-Christian rituals or any magic that it saw as a threat to its supremacy, the use of ritual was already embedded in practices accepted by both the Church and the state. For example, Christian priests routinely followed an array of rites. Another officially acceptable rite, which had parallels with magical healing, stemmed from belief in the divine